

Vote-Selling and Vote-Buying: Does the House Always Win? Gambling Votes in the Lab

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Abstract

Most research on clientelism treats parties as active buyers and voters as passive targets. We argue that this misses vote selling, where voters initiate transactions and price their support. Building on prospect theory, we develop a formal model in which initiative shifts bargaining power, perceived electoral risk, and surplus allocation. Loss aversion provides one mechanism through which electorally exposed parties may overpay to avoid defeat. A laboratory experiment varying initiative, ideology, electoral strength, and pivotality supports the model's behavioral implications. Party-initiated vote buying concentrates offers among ideologically proximate voters and generates higher voter payoffs. Voter-initiated vote selling shifts requested prices toward electorally advantaged parties, especially when they are ideologically distant, but exposes voters to rejection risk and does not necessarily increase voter surplus.

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I. THE NEGLECTED VOTER IN CLIENTELISM RESEARCH

Non-programmatic linkages (Kitschelt 2000) are reciprocal (Auyero 2000; Finan and Schechter 2012). That is, the clientelist exchange usually happens between parties *and* voters, where the former provide particularistic benefits and the latter provide electoral support (Nichter 2008; Nichter 2014). Yet most quantitative scholars have overlooked voters' preferences, thus failing to describe the available strategies of vote sellers. We believe the literature often focuses mostly on parties and how they target individuals. As we note in this paper, the clientelism literature is somewhat unbalanced, showing a huge interest in vote buying relative to vote selling (Figure 1). Hence, while the literature has advanced a number of important questions (see Hicken 2011 for an excellent review), most accounts of clientelism tackle the issue from the party's side. In fact, most of what we know about core-swing dynamics in clientelism therefore comes from settings where parties initiate the exchange and decide whom to target (e.g., Cox and McCubbins 1986; Stokes 2005). *But what if the logic of clientelism reverses when initiative shifts? Do voters, acting as strategic sellers, exploit parties' electoral vulnerabilities in ways that invert core-swing targeting predictions? And how does the distribution of surplus change when voters—not parties—set the terms of exchange?* In this paper we take this complementary perspective and ask how these dynamics look when voters initiate the exchange and strategically decide to whom to sell.

This shift is consistent with recent work showing that clientelistic politics cannot be understood exclusively from the perspective of parties and brokers. In their study

of broker selection, Michael and Thachil (2018, p. 1) argue that brokerage competition matters precisely because “clients [can] choose which broker to seek help from and follow.” While their finding does not concern vote selling directly, they reinforce the broader theoretical premise that clients are not merely passive recipients of machine politics.

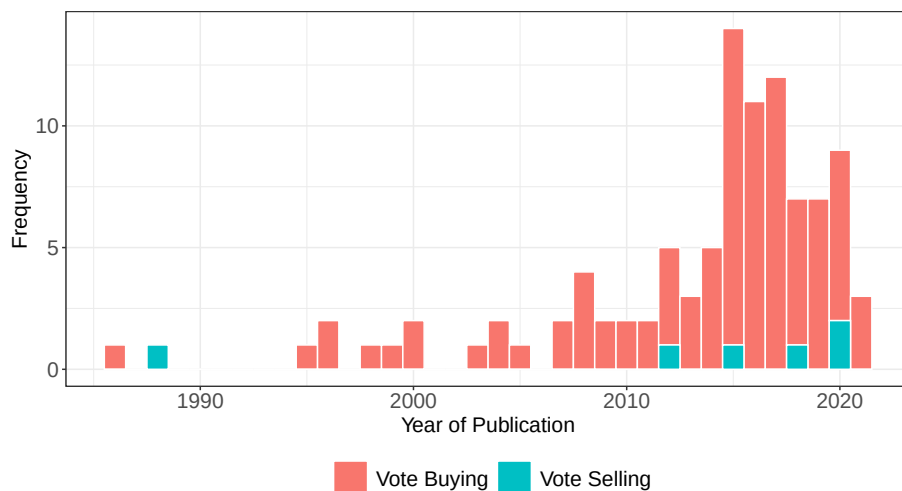


Figure 1: *Annual frequency of Web of Science publications whose abstracts include the terms “vote buying” and “vote selling.”*

This imbalance has substantive consequences. Because quantitative work has overwhelmingly examined party-initiated vote buying, we have comparatively little systematic evidence on vote selling and on how voters behave when they can initiate the exchange. Only a small number of quantitative studies analyze vote selling directly. Hicken et al. (2015) conduct laboratory experiments in the Philippines examining vote selling as a strategic choice, while Bahamonde (2022) provides U.S. survey evidence on vote selling behavior. Importantly, Gherghina and Tap (2026, p. 333) specifically focus on vote selling in Romania, finding that “most people assign

high financial value to their vote,” and that this value is “often independent from poverty” (relatedly, see Bahamonde 2018). However, neither study examines how institutional design—specifically, who initiates the exchange—shapes targeting and pricing, which is the focus of our contribution.

We do not claim that voter-initiated exchange is the dominant form of clientelism in all settings. The empirical prevalence of vote selling likely varies across institutional contexts, broker networks, poverty, monitoring capacity, and electoral competitiveness. Our claim is instead analytical: once voters can initiate, solicit, or price electoral support, the standard party-centered logic of targeting and surplus allocation can change. Existing field and survey evidence suggests that vote selling is not merely hypothetical, thus the central contribution of this paper is to identify the bargaining logic that follows when initiative shifts to the voter side.

A simple question has gone largely unanswered: *Which setting—vote buying or vote selling—is more convenient for either side (parties and voters)?* Ethnographers have raised similar issues. For example, Hagene (2015, p. 152) notes that many clientelist relationships are “client-initiated.” Tosoni (2007, pp. 55–57) explores instances where slum dwellers in México strategically approach brokers to solve collective needs, while Gay (1999) describes how neighborhood associations in Brazilian *favelas* attract resources in exchange for electoral support. These ethnographic accounts suggest that voters and community leaders play an active role in initiating and structuring exchanges. This bottom-up perspective is also supported by evidence on everyday broker–client relations. Michael Auerbach and Thachil (2020, p. 471) note that “client requests” are often central to broker–voter interaction, and argue that explaining

broker responsiveness to such requests is crucial for understanding distributive politics. Our paper moves from requests for assistance to the electoral market itself, asking what happens when voters initiate the transaction and price their support.

At the same time, many studies that do include voters are still embedded in a vote-buying framework. For instance, González-Ocantos, Jonge, et al. (2012), González-Ocantos, Kiewiet de Jonge, and Nickerson (2014), and Kiewiet de Jonge (2015) find that *voters* systematically lie when asked directly about vote *buying*. These contributions clarify a number of important problems, but they do not tell us much about preferences, dynamics, or strategies that are *specific* to vote sellers. Implicitly, voters are often treated as passive receivers of clientelism. That said, recent quantitative work has begun to foreground voters’ agency by showing that they are motivated actors who adjust their participation in clientelistic exchanges based on party competitiveness and their own political orientations (Saikkonen 2021; Gherghina and Saikkonen 2023). Building on this line of research, we push the voter-centered perspective one step further by modeling and measuring voters not only as respondents to offers, but also as strategic initiators who set prices and choose whom to approach.

Conceptually, clientelism is not so different from any other market: there is an arena (campaigns), buyers (parties), and sellers (voters).¹ Classic demand and supply arguments then suggest that we must understand both sides of the exchange. However, most of the literature has concentrated on the demand side—party targeting, resource

¹Other arenas beyond campaigns clearly exist. Hagene (2015) provides an excellent discussion of the differences between “vote buying” and “clientelism.” The former is short term (elections), while the latter may be sustained in the long term and accompanied by affective, personal, and problem-solving elements. For simplicity, we focus on the short-term, electoral aspect here.

allocation, and monitoring—while forgetting about the supplier. Our starting point is that a full account of clientelism requires modeling and measuring the supply side as well: when voters choose to sell, to whom, and at what price.

This perspective also reframes long-standing debates about targeting. One canonical question is whether parties target core constituencies or swing voters (Carlin and Moseley 2015). On the one hand, Cox and McCubbins (1986) and Zarazaga (2016, p. 7) argue that constituencies that are well known to clientelist parties receive more resources. On the other hand, Lindbeck and Weibull (1987), Dixit and Londregan (1996), Dahlberg and Johansson (2002), and Stokes (2005) contend that allocating resources to voters who would support the party anyway is wasteful, so parties should instead focus on swing voters. Yet both sides of this debate are typically framed from the party’s perspective. We know less about how different kinds of voters position themselves in clientelistic markets, who initiates exchanges, and how that interacts with partisan targeting.

Taken together, the literature provides a detailed picture of how parties target core and swing voters, but it remains somewhat silent about how core and swing vote sellers behave when they can initiate exchanges. Core-swing distinctions are usually derived from the party’s optimization problem, leaving the supplier side under-theorized. Yet prior research shows that voters’ collective characteristics can meaningfully shift the logic of targeting (Bahamonde 2018). We believe that once voters’ pricing decisions are modeled directly, the familiar core–swing logic changes. In this paper we suggest that instead of only asking which voters parties can buy at minimal cost, we also ask which parties voters can most profitably sell to. This

shift in perspective reveals how core and swing *vote sellers* position themselves in the clientelistic market and how their strategic choices differ from the patterns implied by party-initiated exchanges. Finally, there is a growing methodological consensus that experimental methods are particularly well suited to address such questions. Following Aldrich and Lupia (2011) and McDermott (2002), and in line with the view that experiments are a promising tool for the study of democracy and development (De La O and Wantchekon 2011), we use an economic experiment to place voters and parties on equal analytical footing.

This paper proceeds as follows. Section II develops a theoretical framework that treats vote buying and vote selling as two institutional variants of the same clientelistic exchange and derives three hypotheses about initiative, electoral risk, and surplus allocation. Section III formalizes these intuitions in a prospect-theoretic model of clientelistic exchange. The model shows how ideological distance determines the minimum compensating transfer, how electoral loss aversion expands parties' effective willingness to pay, and how initiative shapes both targeting and surplus allocation. Section IV describes the experimental design that implements these institutional variants in the laboratory. Section V outlines our econometric strategy for evaluating each hypothesis and presents the empirical results, showing that initiative systematically reverses core–swing patterns and redistributes surplus between voters and parties. Section VI discusses the broader implications of our findings, acknowledges the limitations of our laboratory setting, and identifies avenues for future research.

II. BRINGING VOTERS BACK IN

Clientelistic exchanges are best understood as strategic interactions in a market-like environment in which parties and voters negotiate over private benefits during electoral campaigns. Yet most existing work focuses on the demand side of this market: how parties decide whether to buy votes, whom they target, and how electoral risk shapes their decisions. The supply side—voters’ incentives to sell, whom they approach, and how they strategically price their votes—remains comparatively understudied.

We draw on the institutional literature (North 1981; North 1990) to conceptualize clientelism as a rule-governed exchange in which outcomes depend critically on who moves first and what choices are available at each stage. Under this view, vote buying and vote selling are two institutional variants of the same underlying transaction that differ only in their sequencing rule—specifically, in whether parties or voters initiate the exchange. This difference in initiative reshapes constraints, bargaining positions, and the timing of commitment, even though preferences, payoffs, and the traded good are identical. Classic core-swing targeting arguments implicitly assume that parties initiate and voters respond. Our framework retains this logic but adds the mirror case in which voters initiate and parties respond, allowing us to compare targeting and surplus allocation from both sides of the clientelistic market.

Building on applications of prospect theory to clientelism (Bahamonde and Canales 2022), we argue that initiative matters not because it mechanically changes parties’ willingness to pay, but because it changes when parties must confront the possibility of electoral loss and when they can screen costly transfers. When parties initiate

vote buying, they must decide *ex ante* whether to insure against electoral defeat. If parties overweight prospective losses relative to comparable gains, electoral risk can lead them to offer more than the minimal compensating transfer required to secure support. This behavioral tendency should inflate the material benefits voters receive.

By contrast, when voters initiate vote selling, the strategic environment is inverted. Voters propose prices to parties, but parties evaluate these proposals before committing resources. Even if parties are loss averse, this screening stage allows them to reject costly prices before converting electoral risk into an actual transfer. As a result, voter initiative can generate high requested prices, but it also exposes voters to rejection when their demands exceed parties' effective willingness to pay.

This logic yields clear implications for targeting. In party-initiated vote buying, parties must choose whom to approach. Because the ideological distance between a voter and her less-preferred party increases the compensating transfer required to overturn partisan preferences, it is cheaper to buy support from a core supporter than from an opponent. This reproduces the classic core-targeting intuition: minimal-cost vote buying directs transfers toward ideologically proximate voters (Cox and McCubbins 1986; Zarazaga 2016).

Reversing the order of moves changes how voters position themselves in the clientelistic market. Building on prospect theory (Tversky and Kahneman 1992), we posit that electorally advantaged parties evaluate even small risks of defeat as losses and overweight them. Low-probability defeats are therefore treated as potentially catastrophic, triggering strong insurance motives (Levy 1992, p. 184). From the voter's perspective, this makes electorally strong parties particularly attractive counterparts.

Importantly, this is not because initiative increases willingness to pay *per se*, but because voters can strategically exploit pre-existing loss aversion when they are allowed to set prices.

Initiative also shapes utilities by determining who captures the surplus generated by loss-averse behavior. When parties initiate vote buying, loss aversion operates at the moment of commitment, leading parties to overspend and allowing voters to capture a larger share of the surplus. When voters initiate vote selling, by contrast, parties can screen and reject costly proposals before committing to insure against defeat, leaving some voters with only ideological payoffs. Together, these patterns imply that voters should earn higher expected payoffs when parties move first, whereas parties should fare at least as well—and often better—when voters initiate the exchange, provided that party-initiated offers include a positive insurance premium and voter-initiated requests are rejected with sufficient frequency.

The role of loss aversion differs across these expectations. Core targeting under party initiative follows from ideological proximity and the lower compensating transfer required to secure proximate voters. Similarly, higher voter requests from electorally strong parties follow from voters' expectations about parties' effective willingness to pay. Loss aversion amplifies this willingness to pay when electoral loss is salient. It is therefore most directly implicated in the payoff prediction: party-initiated exchange should generate higher voter payoffs when parties offer an insurance premium above the minimum compensating transfer required to secure support.

The three hypotheses below make these contrasts explicit by pairing the party-initiated logic of core targeting with a voter-initiated logic of requesting higher

prices from electorally strong opponents, and by comparing payoffs across the two institutional variants.

Hypothesis H₁ (Core Targeting Under Party Initiative): When parties initiate the exchange, they are more likely to make offers to ideologically proximate voters than to ideologically distant opponents. Conditional on targeting distant voters, however, parties may need to offer larger transfers to compensate for ideological distance.

Hypothesis H₂ (Selling to Electorally Strong Parties): When voters initiate the exchange, they request higher prices from parties with larger effective willingness to pay, especially electorally strong parties whose risk of losing makes the negotiated vote valuable. This pricing effect is strongest when the party is ideologically distant and electorally strong.

Hypothesis H₃ (Higher Voter Payoffs Under Party Initiative): When parties initiate vote buying, electoral risk can induce them to offer an insurance premium above the minimum compensating transfer required to secure support. When voters initiate vote selling, by contrast, parties evaluate proposed prices before committing resources and can reject costly requests. As a result, voters should receive higher expected payoffs under party-initiated vote buying than under voter-initiated vote selling when party offers include a positive insurance premium and rejection is sufficiently common in the voter-initiated game.

III. A PROSPECT-THEORETIC MODEL OF VOTE BUYING AND VOTE SELLING

In this section we formalize the argument in a simple spatial model of clientelistic exchange. The model has two purposes. First, it identifies the ideological cost of buying a vote: parties must compensate voters for supporting a less-preferred alternative. Second, it incorporates the prospect-theoretic claim that parties evaluate possible electoral defeat as a loss relative to a reference point, which increases their willingness to insure against adverse electoral outcomes. The key comparison is institutional: in vote buying, parties initiate the exchange and commit resources before observing the voter's final choice; in vote selling, voters set prices and parties can accept or reject those prices before committing resources.

I. Players, ideology, and transfers

There are two parties, L and R , with policy positions γ_L and γ_R on a one-dimensional policy space $\Gamma = \{1, \dots, 100\}$. Voter j has ideal point x_j . If party i wins and implements policy γ_i , voter j 's ideological utility is

$$u_j(\gamma_i) = D - |x_j - \gamma_i|, \tag{1}$$

where D is sufficiently large to keep ideological utility non-negative. If voter j supports party i and receives transfer $t_i \geq 0$, total voter utility is

$$U_j(i, t_i) = u_j(\gamma_i) + t_i. \quad (2)$$

Let i^* denote the voter's preferred party:

$$i^* = \arg \max_{i \in \{L, R\}} u_j(\gamma_i). \quad (3)$$

The voter's ideological advantage for the preferred party is

$$\Delta \equiv u_j(\gamma_{i^*}) - u_j(\gamma_{-i^*}) > 0. \quad (4)$$

Thus, Δ is the minimum ideological compensation required to make the voter willing to support the less-preferred party, holding transfers from the preferred party fixed.

Each party has budget $B_i > 0$. Party i 's expected electoral stake from securing the negotiated voter is

$$R_i = q(v_i, P_d)W_i, \quad (5)$$

where $W_i > 0$ is the value of winning, v_i denotes party i 's electoral position, and P_d denotes whether the negotiated voter is pivotal in dyad d . The function $q(v_i, P_d) \in$

$[0, 1]$ captures the extent to which securing the voter protects party i from electoral loss. In the experiment, we operationalize this electoral-risk component with two observable features: the party’s initial vote share and an indicator for whether the negotiated voter is pivotal.

II. Party loss aversion

Under expected-payoff maximization, party i ’s willingness to pay for the voter is bounded by R_i . A party would not rationally spend more than the expected electoral value of the vote. Our theoretical framework departs from this benchmark by assuming that parties evaluate possible electoral defeat relative to a reference point. Let $\lambda_i \geq 1$ denote party i ’s loss-aversion parameter, where $\lambda_i = 1$ corresponds to the expected-payoff benchmark and $\lambda_i > 1$ captures the prospect-theoretic claim that losses, evaluated relative to a reference point, loom larger than comparable gains (Kahneman and Tversky 1979).

Let $\ell_i \in [0, 1]$ denote the salience of electoral loss for party i . Loss salience is higher when the negotiated vote can plausibly affect the party’s electoral outcome: for example, when the voter is pivotal, when the party holds an electorally favorable but vulnerable position, or when failing to secure the vote would turn a likely victory into a possible defeat. Party i ’s prospect-theoretic valuation of securing the negotiated voter is

$$\tilde{R}_i = [1 + (\lambda_i - 1)\ell_i] R_i. \tag{6}$$

When $\lambda_i = 1$ or $\ell_i = 0$, this collapses to the expected-payoff valuation R_i . When $\lambda_i > 1$ and electoral loss is salient, the party's perceived value of buying insurance against defeat exceeds the expected-payoff value of the vote.

Because parties cannot spend more than their available resources, define party i 's effective willingness to pay as

$$\bar{R}_i = \min\{B_i, \tilde{R}_i\}. \quad (7)$$

This term is central to both institutional variants. It is the maximum transfer party i is willing and able to pay for the negotiated vote.

III. Vote selling: voters set prices

We first consider the voter-initiated game. The voter observes ideology, budgets, and parties' electoral positions. The voter then proposes a transfer request $a_i \geq 0$ to each party i . Each party simultaneously accepts or rejects the requested price. If at least one party accepts, the voter supports the accepting party that maximizes $u_j(\gamma_i) + a_i$. If no party accepts, the voter votes according to ideology.

Party i accepts a request a_i only if the requested transfer does not exceed its effective willingness to pay:

$$a_i \leq \bar{R}_i. \quad (8)$$

Anticipating this acceptance rule, the voter chooses requests subject to the parties' participation constraints. A request above R_i is rejected, while a request at or below R_i is acceptable. Thus, R_i is the highest acceptable price from party i . Voters may nevertheless request more than R_i , in which case they face rejection risk. The central comparative static is therefore that the ceiling on acceptable vote-selling prices rises with parties' effective willingness to pay

Proposition 1 (Voter-initiated pricing). *In the voter-initiated game, the highest acceptable price the voter can request from party i is $\bar{R}_i$. The voter sells to the party that maximizes*

$$u_j(\gamma_i) + \bar{R}_i.$$

The voter supports the less-preferred party if and only if

$$\bar{R}_{-i^*} - \bar{R}_{i^*} \geq \Delta.$$

Proof. By Equation 8, party i rejects any request above $\bar{R}_i$ and accepts any request weakly below $\bar{R}_i$. Therefore, the voter cannot extract more than $\bar{R}_i$ from party i . Conditional on acceptance, the voter chooses the party that maximizes ideological utility plus the accepted transfer. The less-preferred party is chosen when its accepted transfer advantage is at least as large as the voter's ideological advantage for the preferred party. $\square$

This proposition generates the vote-selling prediction. Voters demand higher prices from parties with larger effective willingness to pay. Because $\bar{R}_i$ increases with electoral stakes, pivotality, and loss salience, parties with more to lose from failing

to secure the vote become attractive targets for vote sellers. In the experiment, this exposure is captured by the party's initial vote share and by whether the negotiated voter is pivotal. However, ideological distance still matters: the larger Δ , the more compensation the voter requires to sell to the less-preferred party.

IV. Vote buying: parties set offers

We now consider the party-initiated game. The environment is the same, but the order of moves changes. Parties simultaneously choose offers $s_i \geq 0$, with $s_i \leq B_i$. The voter observes both offers and supports the party that maximizes $u_j(\gamma_i) + s_i$. If neither offer changes the voter's choice, the voter supports the preferred party.

Party i 's minimum compensating transfer depends on the voter's ideological position and on the rival offer. Given rival offer s_{-i} , party i can secure the voter only if

$$u_j(\gamma_i) + s_i \geq u_j(\gamma_{-i}) + s_{-i}. \quad (9)$$

Equivalently, party i 's minimum required offer is

$$c_i(s_{-i}) = \max\{0, u_j(\gamma_{-i}) + s_{-i} - u_j(\gamma_i)\}. \quad (10)$$

For the voter's preferred party i^* , this cost is relatively low because the voter already prefers that party ideologically. For the less-preferred party, the cost includes

the ideological disadvantage Δ . Thus, buying support from ideologically proximate voters is cheaper than buying support from opponents.

Parties initiate vote buying only when the perceived value of securing the voter exceeds the minimum compensating transfer. Party i is willing to make a successful offer whenever

$$c_i(s_{-i}) \leq \bar{R}_i. \quad (11)$$

When $\lambda_i = 1$, this is the standard expected-payoff condition. When $\lambda_i > 1$ and electoral loss is salient, $\bar{R}_i$ can exceed R_i , allowing parties to make offers that are larger than the expected-payoff value of the vote. This is the formal counterpart of over-insurance.

Proposition 2 (Party-initiated targeting). *In the party-initiated game, the minimum transfer required to secure the negotiated voter is increasing in ideological distance from the party. Therefore, holding budgets and electoral stakes constant, parties are weakly more likely to buy votes from ideologically proximate voters than from ideologically distant opponents.*

Proof. Party i 's minimum successful offer is $c_i(s_{-i})$. This cost is lower when $u_j(\gamma_i)$ is higher relative to $u_j(\gamma_{-i})$. For the voter's preferred party, the ideological advantage reduces the transfer required to secure support. For the less-preferred party, the party must compensate the voter for the ideological loss Δ . Since party i makes a successful offer only when $c_i(s_{-i}) \leq \bar{R}_i$, lower ideological distance makes successful

vote buying more feasible. $\square$

This proposition recovers the core-targeting prediction without requiring the preferred party to pay exactly Δ . The expected-payoff logic explains why proximate voters are cheaper to buy. The prospect-theoretic component explains why parties may still pay more than the minimum compensating transfer when electoral loss is salient.

V. Initiative and surplus

The two institutional variants differ not in preferences, budgets, or ideology, but in when loss-averse insurance is activated. In the party-initiated game, parties must decide how much to offer before the voter chooses. Because the offer is the moment of commitment, electoral loss is salient when parties choose transfers. Loss-averse parties may therefore offer more than the minimum compensating transfer required to secure support, but only up to their effective willingness to pay. Let the party-initiated offer be written as

$$s_i = c_i(s_{-i}) + \rho_i,$$

where $\rho_i \geq 0$ is an insurance premium. The premium is feasible only when the resulting offer satisfies the party's participation constraint,

$$c_i(s_{-i}) + \rho_i \leq \overline{R}_i,$$

or equivalently,

$$0 \leq \rho_i \leq \bar{R}_i - c_i(s_{-i}).$$

Thus, parties can insure against electoral loss only when the minimum compensating transfer is below their effective willingness to pay. Let the desired insurance premium be:

$$\rho_i^* = \rho(\lambda_i, \ell_i, R_i),$$

with

$$\frac{\partial \rho_i^*}{\partial \lambda_i} \geq 0, \quad \frac{\partial \rho_i^*}{\partial \ell_i} \geq 0, \quad \frac{\partial \rho_i^*}{\partial R_i} \geq 0.$$

Conditional on a successful offer being feasible, the feasible insurance premium is therefore

$$\rho_i = \min\{\rho_i^*, \bar{R}_i - c_i(s_{-i})\} \quad \text{when } c_i(s_{-i}) \leq \bar{R}_i.$$

If $c_i(s_{-i}) > \bar{R}_i$, party i cannot make a successful offer.

By contrast, in the voter-initiated game, the voter names prices and parties decide whether to accept them. Parties can reject costly proposals before committing resources. This screening stage limits the voter's ability to extract the full insurance premium from loss-averse parties. Thus, voter-initiated exchange can generate high requested prices, especially from electorally strong parties, but it also produces rejected offers when requested prices exceed $\bar{R}_i$.

Proposition 3 (Initiative and voter payoffs). *When parties are loss averse and electoral loss is salient, party-initiated vote buying yields higher voter transfers than the minimum compensating transfer. Voter-initiated vote selling allows voters to request high prices from electorally exposed parties, but parties can reject prices above $\bar{R}_i$. Therefore, voters receive higher expected payoffs under party-initiated vote buying when the party insurance premium is positive and rejection is sufficiently common in the voter-initiated game.*

Proof. In the party-initiated game, when a successful offer is feasible, voters receive $s_i = c_i(s_{-i}) + \rho_i$, where $\rho_i > 0$ if the desired insurance premium is positive and there is slack in the participation constraint, $c_i(s_{-i}) < \bar{R}_i$. In the voter-initiated game, voters can request up to $\bar{R}_i$, but any request above $\bar{R}_i$ is rejected and yields no transfer from that party. Thus, party initiative increases voter payoffs through the insurance premium, whereas voter initiative exposes voters to rejection risk. Expected voter payoffs are higher under party initiative when the expected insurance premium exceeds the expected loss from rejected voter requests. $\square$

IV. EXPERIMENTAL DESIGN AND PROCEDURES

The experiment implements these two institutional perspectives in a common strategic environment. In both games, the informational structure, ideological positions, budgets, and electoral risks are identical; only the timing of moves differs. This design lets us compare core-swing targeting behavior and payoffs when parties initiate the exchange, as in the existing literature, and when *voters* initiate it, which is the focus of our contribution.

I. Subjects, implementation, and incentives

The experiment was implemented using **oTree** in a laboratory. A total of 102 adult participants were recruited.² Each subject played the game three times, for a total sample size of 306. At the start of each session, subjects completed two practice rounds to ensure comprehension; practice-round data were excluded from the analysis. Throughout the experiment, participants interacted with the interface using neutral labels (e.g., “Party A” and “Party B”; see below), and accumulated payoffs in experimental “points” that were later converted into real monetary earnings.

Each subject played three independent games. For every new game we reran the full randomization: roles (effectively preventing learning effects), ideological positions, party budgets, and initial vote shares were independently drawn afresh. Thus, while subjects could play multiple games, the strategic environment in each round was independent and unfamiliar *ex ante*.

II. Roles, ideology, and electoral risk

At the beginning of every game, participants were randomly assigned to one of three roles—“Party A,” “Party B,” or “Voter”—and each round was played among exactly three players, one in each role. The experiment implements two institutional variants of the same clientelistic exchange, identical in every dimension except the sequencing of

²The study was carried out in Chile, at a laboratory located in Santiago administered jointly by the University of Santiago and Nuffield College, Oxford. Participants were recruited in the university district, received a show-up fee of 2,000 CLP (approximately 2.1 euros), and earned additional performance-based payments. All payoffs during the games were denominated in experimental points, which were converted into Chilean pesos at a fixed exchange rate announced in advance. Sessions took place between April 20 and May 28, 2021.

moves. **Figure 2** shows the flow of the experiment. In the party-initiated vote-buying game, the two parties simultaneously decide how many points to offer before the voter chooses which party to support; in the voter-initiated vote-selling game, the voter first proposes a pair of minimum acceptable transfers and the parties then simultaneously decide whether to accept. All other elements of the strategic environment—ideological positions, budgets, fictional vote shares, pivotality, and payoff consequences—are held constant across the two variants. Thus, this design isolates the effect of initiative on targeting, pricing, and realized payoffs while preserving a common informational structure that matches the formal model.

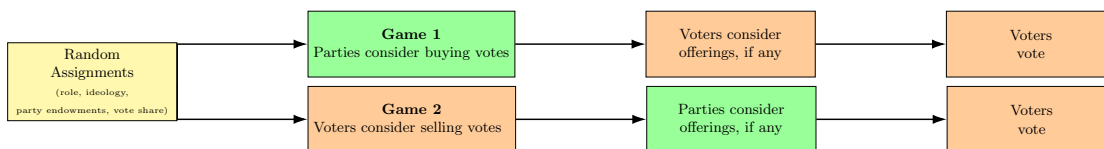


Figure 2: *Flow of the Experimental Games*

Voters were assigned an “ideological” position by being told how many points they would earn if party A or party B won the election. For example, a voter might earn 2,400 points if party A won but only 200 points if party B won, which makes party A their “ideologically” preferred (core) party. Parties also received ideological positions that made them closer or farther from the voter in this payoff space.³ Next, both parties received identical budgets, randomly drawn from a set of possible endowments.⁴ Parties accumulated or lost wealth depending on whether they won the

³This feature reproduces the one-dimensional spatial structure in our formal model: the difference in points across parties for the voter corresponds to the ideological utility difference $u_j(\gamma_{i^*}) - u_j(\gamma_{-i^*})$.

⁴These budgets represent the resources B_i that parties can invest in buying or acquiring votes.

election and on how much they spent on transfers, thus incentivizing optimization over how much to invest in buying votes. Voters similarly gained or lost points depending on which party won, plus any transfers received, thereby creating incentives for optimization in their vote-selling decisions.

To introduce electoral risk and pivotality, we displayed a fictional electorate: each party was assigned an initial vote share, expressed as the number of (hypothetical) voters already committed to supporting that party. The total number of fictional voters varied across games (three or five), and the initial allocation of those voters between A and B implied either a safe seat or a close race. The real experimental subject voter in our study could therefore be either pivotal or nonpivotal in this hypothetical electorate.⁵ All of this information (ideology, budgets, contestation, and pivotality) was public knowledge to all participants.

III. Institutional variants: vote buying and vote selling

Game 1: party-initiated vote buying. In the first variant, parties initiate the transaction. After observing the ideological positions, budgets, and initial vote shares, each party simultaneously decides how many points to offer the voter, choosing any non-negative amount up to its budget. Both parties make their offers without observing the other’s choice. Offering zero points is equivalent to not buying votes in that round. The voter then observes both offers (if any) and chooses which party

⁵In the experiment, the pivotal indicator equals 1 only in minimal-winning configurations: specifically, when the fictional electorate consists of three voters with a 2–1 split, or five voters with a 3–2 split, in favor of the voter’s initially preferred party. In all other configurations the voter is nonpivotal (pivotal = 0), including 3–0, 1–2, 0–3 in three-voter electorates, and 4–1, 1–4, 5–0, or 0–5 in five-voter electorates. Consequently, pivotal = 0 corresponds to multiple distinct vote shares, whereas pivotal = 1 is restricted to a narrow set of knife-edge cases.

to support. If at least one party makes an offer, voting for that party yields the corresponding transfer plus the ideological payoff associated with that party's victory. If both parties make offers, the voter chooses one (or none). If no party makes an offer, the voter, in expectation, simply votes for the party that gives them higher ideological payoff. After the vote is cast, a hypothetical election is resolved and payoffs are realized.

Game 2: voter-initiated vote selling. In the second variant, the order of moves is reversed while holding fixed the information structure and payoffs. After observing ideology, budgets, and vote shares, the voter proposes a pair of minimum acceptable transfers, one for each party. Each party submits its decision without observing the other party's decision. These requested prices represent the minimum amount the voter is willing to accept from each party in exchange for their vote. Parties then simultaneously decide whether to accept or reject the requested price. A party pays the requested amount only if it accepts the offer and the voter ultimately chooses it. If at least one party accepts, the voter chooses which party to support, taking into account both the requested transfer and their ideological preferences. If no party accepts, the voter again votes solely (and in expectation) on ideology. As before, after the vote is cast the election is resolved and material payoffs are realized.

V. ECONOMETRIC STRATEGY

This section links our theoretical predictions to the experimental data by testing the three hypotheses outlined above. We interpret the estimates as behavioral

tests of the model’s comparative statics, not as direct estimates of equilibrium strategies or structural parameters. We proceed in four steps. First, we describe the empirical distributions of vote-buying offers and vote-selling requests to motivate our modeling choices (Figure 3). Second, we test core targeting under party initiative (Hypothesis H₁) by modeling parties’ offers in the vote-buying game (Figure 4). Third, we analyze how voters price their vote under voter-initiated exchange (Hypothesis H₂) using the vote-selling model with an interaction between ideological distance and electoral strength (Figure 5). Finally, we compare observed payoffs across institutional variants to assess whether party initiative generates higher voter payoffs, as expected when party offers include an insurance premium and voter-initiated requests are vulnerable to rejection (Hypothesis H₃; Figure 6).

I. Distributions of vote-buying offers and vote-selling requests

Figure 3 displays the empirical distributions of the dependent variables in both games: the offers made by parties in the vote-buying game (left panel) and the minimum acceptable transfers that voters request in the vote-selling game (right panel). The two distributions differ sharply in ways that reflect the strategic logic of each environment.

Vote-buying offers cluster heavily at two points: zero (opting not to buy) and a small interior value corresponding to the compensating transfer implied by the ideological distance between the voter and the party. This pattern is consistent with the formal logic in Section III: parties are less likely to make offers when ideological distance raises the cost of buying support, while positive offers must compensate voters for the ideological loss associated with supporting a less-preferred party.

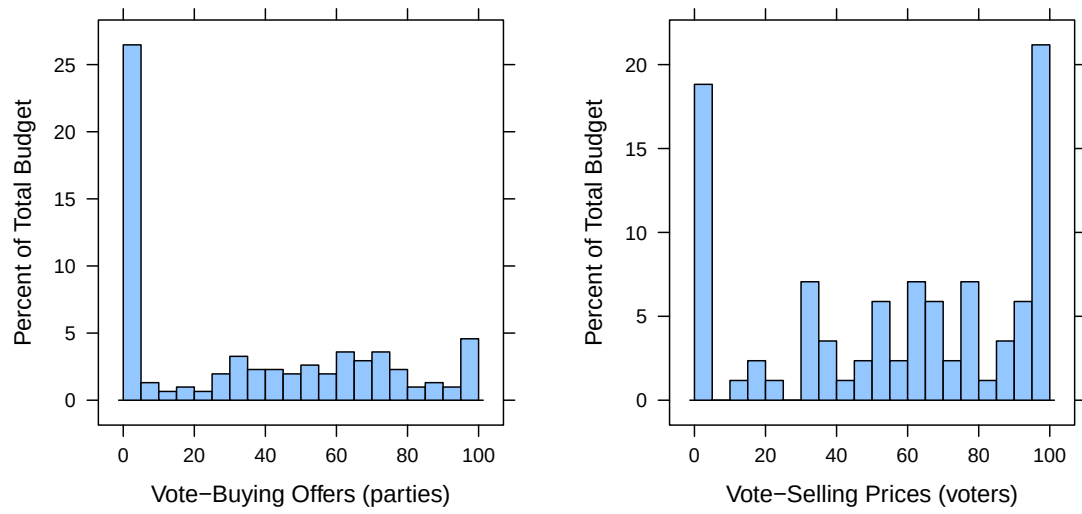


Figure 3: *Distributions of vote-buying offers (left panel) and vote-selling prices (right panel), expressed as a percentage of each party's total budget (public information in all games).*

By contrast, vote-selling requests are more dispersed. Many voters request close to zero from at least one party, indicating that ideological benefits alone sometimes suffice to secure their support. At the same time, a substantial share of requests approach or reach the full party budget (especially when bargaining with electorally strong parties, as [Figure 5](#) suggests). This variation makes the vote-selling environment particularly well suited for testing how ideological distance and electoral stakes jointly shape pricing behavior.

II. Core targeting under party initiative

To test [Hypothesis H₁](#), we estimate two models of party behavior in the vote-buying game: one predicting the *size* of positive offers ([Equation 12](#)) and another predicting whether a party makes *any* offer.⁶ Both specifications include ideological distance, vote share, and pivotality as predictors. The results of both models are summarized in [Figure 4](#).

For the continuous specification, we model the size of the offer that party i makes to the voter in dyad d as a function of ideological distance, electoral strength, and pivotality:

$$\text{Offer}_{di} = \alpha_0 + \alpha_1 \text{Ideology}_{di} + \alpha_2 \text{VoteShare}_{di} + \alpha_3 \text{Pivotal}_d + \nu_{di} \quad (12)$$

Here, Offer_{di} is the (strictly positive) transfer the party proposes; Ideology_{di} is the ideological distance between the party and the voter; VoteShare_{di} is the party's initial

⁶For this specification, we estimate a logit model for the probability that a party makes any offer. Both models suggest the same substantive results. See [Table A1](#).

vote share in the fictional electorate; and Pivotal_d is an indicator for whether the real voter is pivotal in that dyad. Standard errors are clustered by party participant level.

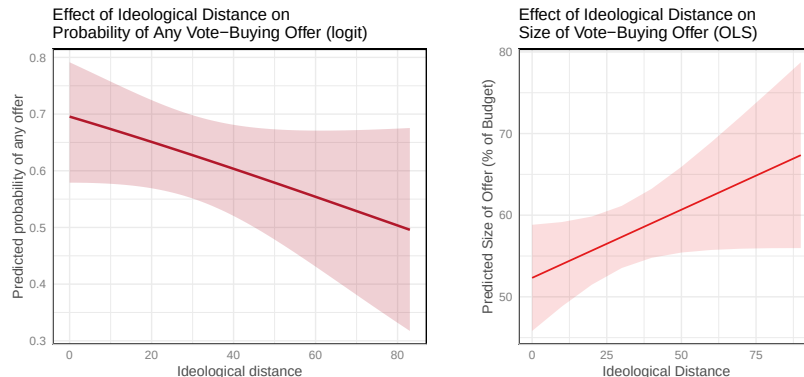


Figure 4: *Predicted probability of making any vote-buying offer (left panel) and predicted size of vote-buying offers conditional on a positive offer (right panel) as a function of ideological distance. Predictions obtained from Equation 12 and the corresponding logit model for any offer (see Table A1). Shaded regions show 95% cluster-robust confidence intervals.*

The two models capture distinct margins of party behavior. As ideological distance increases, parties become less likely to make any offer at all (left panel). Conditional on making an offer, however, parties pay larger transfers to ideologically more distant voters (right panel), reflecting the higher compensation required to overturn ideological preferences. Thus, H_1 is supported primarily on the extensive margin: parties are less likely to target ideologically distant voters, even though successful offers to such voters must be larger when they are made. Because the experiment does not separately identify the minimum compensating transfer and the insurance premium, we use offer size and payoff differences as behavioral implications of this mechanism rather than as direct estimates of ρ_i .

III. Who pays how much? Ideology, electoral strength, and the price of a vote

The vote-selling environment is where core-swing behavior can be studied from the seller’s perspective—which is the core of our contribution—and it therefore becomes the focus of our identification strategy. This setting allows us to test one of the key comparative statics implied in [Section III](#): that voters should demand higher prices from parties with greater effective willingness to pay, especially when those parties are ideologically distant and electorally exposed. The dependent variable in the vote-selling model is the price that the voter requests from party i in dyad d , expressed as a percentage of party i ’s budget.⁷

In [Equation 13](#), the main explanatory variables are the ideological distance between the voter and party i and the party’s electoral position, measured as its initial vote share in the fictional electorate. Ideological distance is defined as the absolute difference between the voter’s ideological payoff and the party’s ideological payoff. Vote share captures the party’s electoral position, while the pivotality indicator captures whether the negotiated voter can directly affect the electoral outcome. Together, these variables operationalize the observable electoral-risk component $q(v_i, P_d)$ of the electoral-stake term $R_i = q(v_i, P_d)W_i$, rather than R_i in its entirety.

⁷Formally,

$$Y_{di} \equiv \frac{a_{di}}{B_{di}} \times 100,$$

where a_{di} is the transfer requested from party i and B_{di} is that party’s budget. This transformation makes prices comparable across rounds with different budgets and expresses each request as a share of the resources available to that party. Thus, Y_{di} is the percentage of party i ’s budget that the voter requests in the voter-initiated game.

Because the experimental payoff structure fixes the value of winning, variation in vote share and pivotality captures variation in parties' exposure to electoral loss. The constant term captures the baseline level of requested prices when all covariates are at zero.

The theoretical logic of vote selling further implies that the effect of ideology on requested prices depends on how much each party stands to gain from securing the negotiated vote—that is, ideological distance should matter differently for electorally weak versus electorally strong parties. To capture this heterogeneity, we include an interaction between ideological distance and electoral strength (see [Table A1](#)).⁸ This interaction term allows the slope of ideological distance to vary across different levels of vote share.

We therefore estimate the following linear model:

$$Y_{di} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Ideology}_{di} + \beta_2 \text{VoteShare}_{di} + \beta_3 \text{Ideology}_{di} \times \text{VoteShare}_{di} + \beta_4 \text{Pivotal}_d + \varepsilon_{di}. \quad (13)$$

Standard errors are clustered by voter participant to account for repeated observations from the same voter across rounds (see [Table A1](#)).

[Figure 5](#) presents the marginal effects obtained after fitting [Equation 13](#). The figure plots predicted requested prices as a function of ideological distance for electorally weak parties (20 percent initial vote share) and electorally strong parties (80 percent initial vote share).

⁸Following Brambor, Clark, and Golder (2006, p. 77), we do not interpret the coefficients of the constitutive terms in [Table A1](#) as they lack substantive meaning.

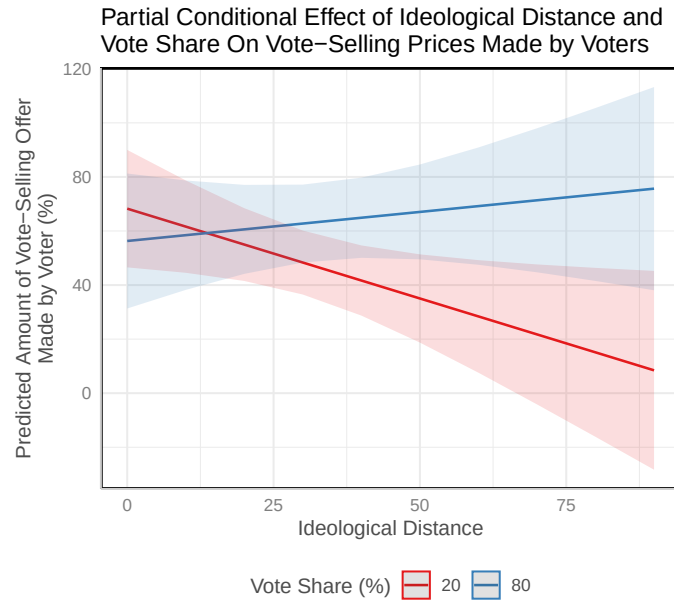


Figure 5: *Predicted vote-selling prices as a function of ideological distance and electoral strength. Shaded regions show 90% cluster-robust confidence intervals. Predictions from [Equation 13](#).*

Two findings emerge. First, when bargaining with electorally weak parties, requested prices decline as ideological distance increases. When the weak party is ideologically close, voters can request relatively high transfers because supporting that party imposes little ideological cost. As ideological distance grows, the ideological payoff from supporting that party falls, and voters request lower prices; for large distances, the predicted request approaches zero. Second, when bargaining with electorally strong parties, the relationship reverses: requested prices increase with ideological distance. When the strong party is ideologically proximate, voters request moderate transfers. But as ideological distance widens, voters sharply escalate their demands, often approaching the maximum amount the party can afford. This reflects the fact that strong parties have a higher stake in securing the negotiated vote and therefore, when the budget constraint does not bind, a higher effective willingness to pay (Bahamonde and Canales 2022).⁹

The point estimate on the pivotal-voter indicator is positive but highly imprecise, and we do not find clear evidence that pivotal voters systematically request higher transfers (Table A1). Taken together, these results provide empirical support for the electoral-strength component of Hypothesis H₂: voters request higher prices from electorally strong parties, especially when those parties are ideologically distant. We find less evidence that pivotality, measured separately, systematically increases requested prices. Vote selling therefore shifts requested prices toward electorally strong opponents in the configurations where electoral strength makes the negotiated vote more valuable, as predicted in the formal model.

⁹In the formal model, electoral strength enters R_i , which in turn raises effective willingness to pay $\bar{R}_i$ when the budget constraint does not bind.

IV. Who benefits when the rules change? Payoffs across institutional variants

Finally, we examine how initiative shapes the distribution of surplus between voters and parties across the two institutional variants (**Hypothesis H₃**). For each round, we compute the total payoff earned by voters and by parties under vote buying and vote selling.¹⁰ We then calculate design-based mean payoffs and non-parametric 90 percent confidence intervals for the mean in each institutional setting. Because subjects can appear in multiple rounds, we also conduct a one-sided difference-in-means test for voter payoffs across games. Random assignment of institutional variants across rounds ensures that differences in mean payoffs identify the causal effect of initiative on surplus allocation.

Figure 6 compares average payoffs for voters and parties across the two institutional variants. The left panel shows that parties earn similar or slightly higher payoffs in the voter-initiated vote-selling game relative to the party-initiated vote-buying game. The confidence intervals overlap substantially, indicating that parties do not lose from shifting initiative to voters.

The right panel shows a different pattern for voters. Because the experiment does not directly measure parties' loss-aversion parameters, the payoff comparison should be interpreted as a test of the behavioral implication of the model rather than as direct evidence of the psychological mechanism itself. Average voter payoffs are higher when parties initiate the exchange. This difference is directionally consistent

¹⁰For the party-side comparison, Party A and Party B are pooled because they are symmetric in the design.



Figure 6: *Observed payoffs for voter and party roles under party-initiated vote buying and voter-initiated vote selling, computed as design-based means across experimental rounds with non-parametric 90% confidence intervals for the mean.*

with the prospect-theoretic argument developed in [Section II](#), according to which voters capture more surplus when parties initiate the exchange ([Hypothesis H₃](#)), although the statistical evidence is modest ($p = 0.057$, one-sided). When parties initiate vote buying, observed offers are often larger than the minimal compensating transfer,¹¹ particularly under electoral risk. This pattern is consistent with voters capturing a substantial portion of the surplus created in the exchange. When voters initiate vote selling, they frequently request prices that electorally weak parties cannot afford or choose not to pay. Some voter proposals were extremely high relative to parties' randomly assigned budgets. When requested prices exceeded what a party could afford, or what it was willing to pay, that party rejected the offer, leaving the voter with only the ideological payoff. This increases party payoffs and reduces

¹¹In the formal model, this minimum compensating transfer is captured by $c_i(s_{-i})$. In the special case where the party is the voter's less-preferred party and the rival offer is zero, this corresponds to Δ .

average voter payoffs. Overall, the payoff results support the paper’s central argument that initiative shapes both the direction of transfers and the distribution of surplus. When parties move first, transfers concentrate on core voters and voters appear to capture more of the surplus. When voters move first, they request higher prices from electorally strong opponents, but rejected offers lower their average utilities while leaving party utilities stable or higher. Initiative is therefore a crucial institutional determinant of who benefits from clientelistic exchange.

VI. DISCUSSION

This paper revisits a classic question in the clientelism literature by shifting attention from parties as buyers to voters as strategic sellers. We argued that vote buying and vote selling are best understood as two institutional variants of the same clientelistic exchange, highlighting who moves first and how this sequencing rule structures bargaining power, targeting, and surplus extraction. Building on this institutional perspective, we developed a prospect-theoretic model of initiative and electoral risk, derived comparative statics for party- and voter-initiated exchange, and implemented a laboratory experiment that mirrors the model’s core structure.

Empirically, we find that when parties initiate the exchange, transfers concentrate on core voters, while payoff patterns are directionally consistent with voters receiving higher expected payoffs when parties, rather than voters, move first. When voters initiate, however, they request higher prices from electorally strong opponents and ultimately leave more surplus on the party side because some high requests are rejected. Taken together, these patterns underscore that initiative is not a procedural

detail but a central institutional feature that shapes who benefits from clientelism.

At the same time, our approach has several important limitations. The experiment relies on a stylized, one-shot interaction among anonymous participants, with a single negotiated voter who may or may not be pivotal, simplified information, and short-term payoffs denominated in points. Real-world clientelism unfolds in dense social networks with repeated interactions, reputation, sanctions, and organizational intermediaries, often in settings marked by poverty, uncertainty, and long time horizons. In turn, our design also abstracts from richer strategic dynamics: while our games implement move order in an extensive-form setting, they do not constitute fully dynamic sequential games with multiple stages, repeated play, off-path beliefs, or forward-looking incentives of the kind studied in repeated or stochastic games. These features help enforce agreements in practice but lie outside our experimental framework.

A further limitation concerns clientelist defection. In reality, many clients accept transfers but either vote differently or fail to mobilize as promised. To maintain experimental control, our design deterministically ties completed exchange to delivery: when an accepted offer or requested price is selected by the voter, the corresponding vote is cast. This removes a central real-world uncertainty. Future experiments could incorporate probabilistic compliance, moral-hazard structures, noisy or manipulable monitoring technologies, or repeated-play incentives that generate endogenous reputation and strategic retaliation.

Another limitation is the two-party, one-voter structure, which creates a bilateral-monopoly environment: two (potential) buyers bargain with a single (potential) seller.

This produces a clean strategic environment but abstracts from richer clientelistic ecosystems where parties face multiple voters, and voters face multiple competing brokers. Extending this framework to two parties and multiple voters would introduce congestion, coordination problems, and competition among sellers. Similarly, introducing more than two parties would turn the vote-selling stage into a multi-lateral bargaining environment: voters could play parties against each other, and parties could strategically coordinate or differentiate offers. Some extensions resemble ultimatum-like bargaining (when one actor proposes terms to multiple counterparts), while others resemble Bertrand competition or contest models with multiple buyers and heterogeneous stakes. These richer designs would illuminate whether the logic of requesting higher prices from electorally strong opponents persists when parties can form expectations about how other buyers will behave, or when voters can strategically sort, coordinate, or defect in groups.

A related limitation concerns prevalence. Our design identifies how initiative shapes pricing, targeting, and surplus allocation when voter-initiated exchange is possible; it does not estimate how frequently such exchanges occur in real elections. The prevalence of vote selling is likely context-dependent and may be lower than party-initiated vote buying in many clientelistic systems. This does not make the mechanism irrelevant. Rather, it clarifies the scope of the contribution: the paper isolates the strategic consequences of voter initiative in clientelistic bargaining, leaving the population-level incidence of voter-initiated exchange to future research.

Given these limitations, we caution against strong claims about external validity: our findings identify mechanisms about initiative, electoral risk, and bargaining in

clientelistic markets, not real-world effect magnitudes, long-run equilibria, or the dynamics of multi-round negotiation. Future research should examine whether the patterns we document extend to field and survey experiments that better approximate real campaigns; incorporate multiple voters, brokers, and networked interactions; and allow for repeated play, trust, monitoring, and reputation. Experimental work using richer extensive-form or multi-stage games could explore how sequential bargaining, dynamic incentives, and off-path beliefs affect targeting and surplus extraction. Cross-national laboratory and lab-in-the-field studies could assess how institutional context, poverty, or risk preferences shape the logic of requesting higher prices from electorally strong opponents. Finally, combining our institutional framework with observational data and ethnographic work on broker strategies would help clarify how often party-versus voter-initiated exchanges occur in practice and to what extent the “house” really wins when voters attempt to exploit parties’ electoral vulnerabilities.

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APPENDIX

Appendix Contents

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I. Vote-buying offers and vote-selling prices

Table A1: *Vote-buying offers and vote-selling prices*

	Offer size (OLS)	Any offer (logit)	Requested price (OLS)
Constant	66.226*** (8.564)	−0.008 (0.475)	72.250*** (20.335)
Ideological distance	0.167 (0.103)	−0.010 (0.007)	−0.958+ (0.533)
Vote share	−0.239+ (0.133)	0.007 (0.008)	−0.199 (0.394)
Pivotal voter	−3.210 (4.654)	1.142*** (0.312)	6.195 (9.976)
Ideology × vote share			0.015 (0.010)
Num.Obs.	125	204	85
R2	0.051		0.074
R2 Adj.	0.027		0.028
Log.Lik.	−581.028	−127.482	−421.652
Std.Errors	Clustered	Clustered	Clustered